

GAMES TO IMPROVE EXECUTIVE FUNCTIONING

IMPULSE
FREEZE



SELF REGULATION
FLEXIBLE THINKING

Impulse Freeze Game

Goal: Help teachers experience how young children develop self-control and impulse regulation.

Directions

Play Simon Says, but with a slight modification:

- If the facilitator doesn't say "Simon says", participants must do the opposite of the command instead of staying still.
- Example: If the facilitator says "Stand on your left foot," participants should not do it, they should "Stand on your right foot".
- Instead of players being "out", the facilitator must support the player in doing the correct action by using an affective statement.

Debrief:

- Discuss how impulse control develops in young children.
- What strategies help students practice this skill in the classroom?
- When students struggle with impulse control, how can affective statements help them reflect on their actions instead of just reacting to consequences?

Affective Statement Examples:

- "I noticed you got frustrated when you moved too quickly. I understand—it's hard to stop when you're excited. I appreciate how you kept trying."
- "I saw that it was tough to hold back, but I also noticed that when you slowed down, you did really well. That was great self-control!"

GAMES TO IMPROVE EXECUTIVE FUNCTIONING

FOLLOW
MY LEAD

WORKING MEMORY

Follow My Lead

Goal: Experience how working memory impacts following directions and recall.

Directions

Memory chain game:

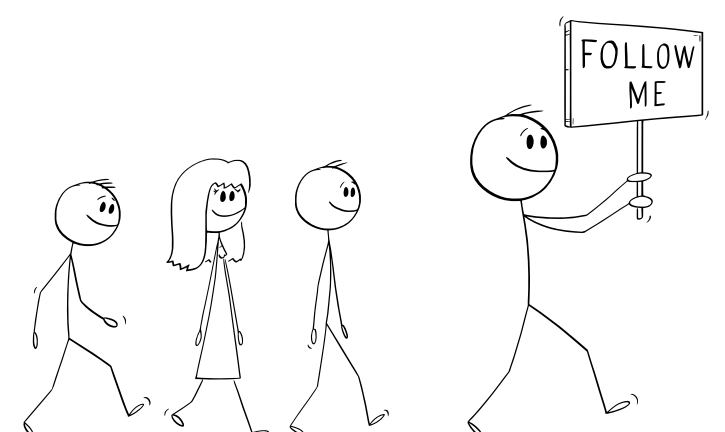
- One participant starts by saying a short movement sequence (e.g., “Clap once, stomp twice”).
- The next participant must repeat the previous sequence and add one new movement.
- This continues around the circle until the sequence becomes too difficult to recall.
- If a player has difficulty remembering the sequence, use an affective statement to support the player.

Debrief:

- How does working memory affect students' ability to follow multi-step directions?
- Discuss strategies for supporting working memory (e.g., visual cues, breaking tasks into smaller steps).
- How can affective statements support students when they forget directions or struggle with multi-step tasks?

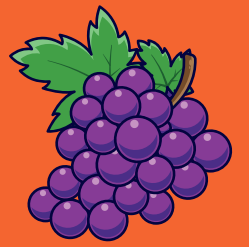
Affective Statement Examples:

- I saw you were frustrated when the sequence got longer. That happens to me too! I appreciate that you kept focusing and trying.
- I can tell that remembering all the steps was tricky, but I noticed that when you repeated them out loud, you got them right! That strategy worked well for you



GAMES TO IMPROVE EXECUTIVE FUNCTIONING

SWITCH IT
UP!



COGNITIVE
FLEXIBILITY

Switch It Up!

Goal: Experience cognitive flexibility.

Directions

Category Flip Game:

- Choose a facilitator.
- Facilitator starts by naming a category (e.g., "Fruits").
- Participants take turns saying a word that fits (e.g., "Apple, Banana, Grape").
- At a random time, the facilitator suddenly switches the category (e.g., "Now name types of vehicles!").
- The group must quickly shift to naming items in the new category.
- Keep changing categories every few seconds to challenge their ability to switch mental gears!
- If a player has difficulty, use an affective statement to support the player to be successful

Debrief:

- What did you notice when switching categories?
- How does cognitive flexibility affect young learners when transitioning between tasks?
- Discuss strategies for supporting cognitive flexibility in students (e.g., transition cues, flexible thinking exercises).
- How can affective statements encourage students to be more adaptable when things don't go as expected?

Affective Statement Examples:

- I noticed you got stuck when the category changed. That happens to me too, and it's really frustrating! I appreciate that you took a deep breath and kept going.
- I could tell that switching gears so quickly was difficult, but I also saw that when you paused and thought about it, you found an answer. That was great flexible thinking!

GAMES TO IMPROVE EXECUTIVE FUNCTIONING

MINDFUL
TOOLS



SELF REGULATION

Mindful Tools

Goal: Experience cognitive flexibility.

Directions

Participate in any of the following, try using each activity:

- Sensory relaxation:
 - Use any of the following to de-stress for the next few minute: balls, fidget toys, mindful coloring.
- Guided Breathing Exercise:
 - Try the "balloon breathing" exercise:
 - Inhale deeply through the nose, expanding the belly like a balloon.
 - Hold for a few seconds.
 - Slowly exhale through the mouth, imagining the balloon deflating.
 - Consider how controlled breathing helps regulate emotions and behavior.

Debrief:

- What are some simple ways to incorporate self-regulation strategies into daily routines?
- How do these tools align with restorative practices?
- How can affective statements help students recognize their emotions and regulate their behavior in challenging moments?

Affective Statement Examples:

- I saw that you were feeling frustrated at first, and I get it—sometimes it's hard to find the right strategy. I appreciate that you kept trying different tools to see what worked for you.
- "I noticed that when you took deep breaths, you seemed to feel more in control. I really admire that you stuck with it instead of giving up.